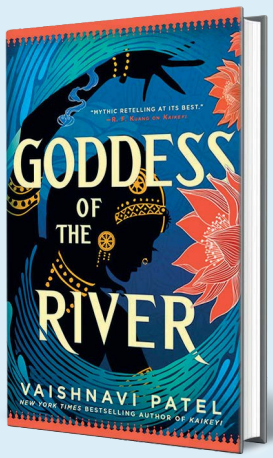


TRIPPING DOWN THE GANGA
A Son's Exploration of Faith
by Siddharth Kapila
SPEAKING TIGER
₹799; 440 pages

GODDESS OF THE RIVER
by Vaishnavi Patel
ORBIT/
HATCHETTE INDIA
₹599; 448 pages



BOOKS

River **Sutras**

Two books about the Ganga, one a fictionalised retelling of the life of the river-goddess, the other a son's journey to prominent Hindu sites along it

Over the last decade or so, there has been an explosion of Indian English novels involving the Mahabharata. But in almost all, Ganga, the river-goddess, seldom rises beyond a quickly forgotten supporting character (Amruta Patil's *Adi Parva* is a notable exception). Vaishnavi Patel's novel *Goddess of the River* corrects the record in style, with a 'reimagining' filled with lively character sketches and a strong sense of Shakespearean foreboding. After Ganga the river-goddess marries the king Shantanu, she has to negotiate the mortal life, that too the life of a queen. Eventually, she is forced to abandon her son Devavrata (the man destined to become the invincible warrior Bheeshma) who then takes a draconian vow never to marry in order to appease his father and his second wife.

What I liked best about the book was the role of Ganga as a kind of super-powerful spectator/occasional participant to the beginnings of the Mahabharata—think of how gods like Ares and Apollo play both witness and participant in *The Iliad*. "I heard again and again about my son's attempts to make peace—to split the kingdom, to pay respects to both parties, to advise against warfare—and I could not help but think that it was his oath that had led to all this. And worse, it was my fault he had made that oath."

The other book involving the Ganga that I enjoyed recently was Siddharth Kapila's *Tripping Down the Ganga*, an astute blend of memoir, travel writing and fly-on-the-wall sociology. It's an account of the author's journeys to Hindu pilgrimage sites along the Ganga between 2015 and 2022. As a schoolboy, Kapila visited Badrinath, Kedarnath et al with his mother and it's this mother-son relationship that acts as an emotional anchor for the book. As a progressive, UK-educated man in a relationship with another man, Kapila's ideas about faith and inclusiveness and religious reform often clash with his mother's—and out of this conflict of ideas comes the bulk of this book.

Kapila's accounts of overcoming his own bias are touching, like when he travels with the much-reviled kanwariyas, and gradually changes his mind about them. By the end of the trip, he respects their religious expression and no longer thinks of the group as a rule-breaking, hard-partying monolith. But Kapila is also harsh on Hinduism and those tasked with running Hindu pilgrimages when he needs to be—hypermercantile, conmen-adjacent priests and sadhus are rightly presented in an unflattering light and in Kapila's view, they are socio-economic bottlenecks holding a great religion back.

> In *Tripping Down the Ganga*, **KAPILA** is harsh on Hinduism and those tasked with running Hindu pilgrimages

The one thing I did not like in the book was the author comparing Hinduism's tolerance levels (especially with regards to issues like gay rights and inter-religious marriage) with Islam, Sikhism, et cetera.

Indians as a whole are largely intolerant of these things, and I don't see how religion plays a role in these choices—we have repeatedly proven this is who we are as a society and as a nation. This minor quibble aside, I wholeheartedly recommend *Tripping Down the Ganga* for its many insights into the "galaxy of divinities, stories and philosophies encompassing the Hindu faith". ■

–Aditya Mani Jha